

BY GABRIEL DAVIDSON

Los Angeles, Cal., July 18. **AP** The ghost of the Channel Islands hasn't bothered anybody for 90 years or so, but, just in case anyone is still worrying about it, a bunch of scientists have come up with a scientific conclusion, which might be expressed unscientifically as:

"That wasn't no ghost. That was an Indian lady."

This whole thing started back in 1853 when seamen, sailing their old windjammers past lonely San Nicholas Island, 65 miles off San Pedro, told of seeing a dark figure silhouetted on the black shoreline. The barren, windswept island was uninhabited, so far as anyone knew, and naturally the phenomenon occasioned much comment in the coastal groghops or wherever it was those old sailors used to congregate.

Well, the story recently attracted the attention of Arthur Woodward, present archaeologist of the Los Angeles County Museum, so he and a group of associates went to work, and the results of their studies became known today. The investigation revealed that there was really more basis for this ghost story than for most such yarns, anyway.

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Woodward disclosed how the mission fathers on the mainland, definitely not believing in ghosts but anxious to find out who or what was spooking up the island, hired one Capt. George Nidever, a sea otter hunter, and Indian fighter from Santa Barbara, to investigate, he presumably being fresh out of sea otters to hunt or Indians to fight.

His diary of an August day in 1853 reads—"At a distance along a high ridge we saw a small, black object. As we neared we saw that it was a woman in an open hut. She was old. She was an Indian, busily employed in stripping blubber from a piece of seal skin held across one knee.

"Charley (one of the crew) stepped around in front of her, and, instead of showing alarm, she smiled and bowed, chattering away in a language wholly unintelligible."

The diary proceeds. She was the silhouette the passing ships had seen. She was the last living link with an ancient civilization on this island.

Eighteen years previously, says

the diary, the mission fathers heard that the Indian people on the island were starving and sent Isaac Sparks to remove the islanders.

Sparks and his crew gathered the surviving dozen Indian men, women and children on the beach. Just as they were preparing to leave, one young woman demanded that she be permitted to go back to the village for her baby. This was granted, but a squall came up and Sparks, fearing his ship would be wrecked, took the rest of the Indians and sailed for San Pedro.

Why the Indian mother was not rescued for the next 18 years has not been determined. When Capt. Nidever found her, she was alone. Later she made known in sign language that her baby had been killed by wild dogs.



Coming now to July, 1943, some of this story has been confirmed, and its long background unearthed by Archeologist Woodward and associates. This group has just completed the records, found in graves and village sites, of the channel islands, San Nicholas, Santa Catalina, Santa Cruz, San Miguel and Santa Rosa.

On one expedition, Woodward followed the explicit directions of Capt. Nidever to the place where the lone mother was found. Woodward's party came upon a hut, presumably the one where the Indian mother had lived. Still standing were a score or more of whale-bones which had been the framework of the hut.

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As the scientists pieced out the pre-history of her ancestors, the channel islands were inhabited by sea-bred Indian fishermen, for uncounted ages before the Spaniards arrived.

Material collected by archeologists, biologists and other scientists indicates that these Indians subsisted almost entirely on what they could get from the sea. The islands appear to have been too barren for agriculture.

When the Spaniards appeared on the coast, some of the islanders drifted to the mainland. During the first part of the 18th century there was a rapid decline in the island populations, due mainly to the diseases of civilization.

What finally happened to the lone mother is a good example. She was taken to the mainland, baptized and christened Juana Maria. But civilization's bounty was too much for her. She died in a few weeks. Capt. Nidaver recorded that he thought her death was due to eating too much fruit.